

! Quality assurance offcuts 1

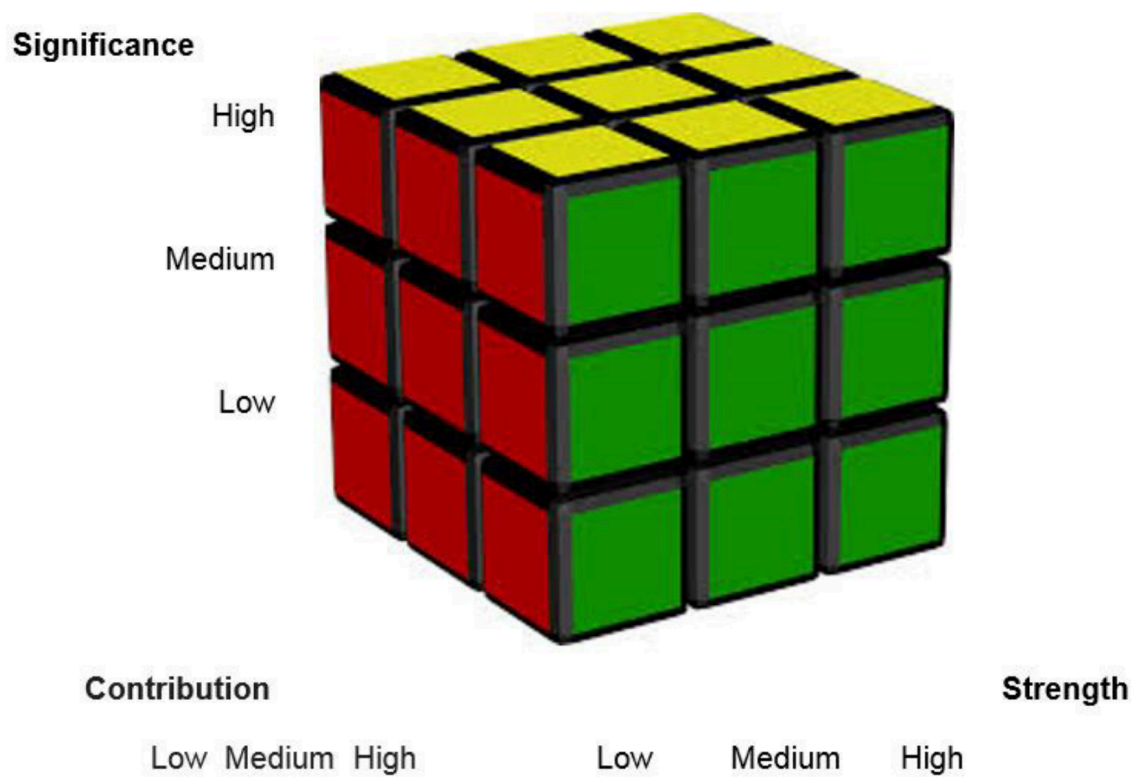
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Not so relevant in our case:

In Aston (2019), based on Mayne (2014), Tom Aston came up with this cube, which suggests an assessment based on significance, contribution and strength of evidence. This does not make quite as much sense in our context, because he is coming from a different place. For example, you are perhaps doing some kind of process tracing and are looking at one particular part of one pathway and asking what's the evidence that this foreground link is having a significant contribution to some outcome. Whereas in causal mapping you have the ambition to have captured information about all the different important contributions in parallel.

What we are proposing here is not specifically about ranking different contributions one against the other, though you could do that too.

Figure 1: Contribution Cube



Aston (2019). Note "Strength" means "Strength of evidence".

What criteria are appropriate for the different moments?

Tom Aston Aston (2019) takes the holistic route and proposes three criteria for assessing contribution to an outcome, each with its own rubric (Mayne 2014):

- Strength (of evidence)

- Contribution
- Significance

Tom Aston and Marina Apgar propose eight holistic rubrics for judging quality for causal inference in single cases (Aston 2019) .

- Plausibility
- Uniqueness
- Triangulation

- Transparency
- Independence
- Representation
- Transferability
- Ethics

We won't bother arguing with the details of these excellent criteria, or whether we really need all of them: we will simply assign them to different moments within the QA task. In this table we assign these 3+8 criteria (rows) to the five moments. They *all* appear in the final, holistic column because in the end the human-in-the-loop has to vouch for the finding.

The point is that you can by all means make a judgement about the plausibility of a single causal claim (column 1) but

	1) Individual claims	2) Bundles of claims	3) Tracing / transitivity	4) Value and contribution	5) Holistic
Strength (of evidence)	?	✓	✓	?	✓
Contribution			✓	✓	✓
Significance				✓	✓
Plausibility	✓	✓	✓		✓
Uniqueness			✓	✓	✓
Triangulation		✓		✓	✓
Transparency	✓	?			✓
Independence	✓				✓
Representation		✓			✓
Transferability		✓			✓
Ethics	?	?			✓

References

Aston (2019). *Contribution Rubrics*. https://media.licdn.com/dms/document/media/C4D1FAQE1laRiovFrQ/feedshare-document-pdf-analyzed/o/1620553059516?e=1687996800&v=beta&t=bFr7dhpZ-slluV8ne1cERFelwINiaEzsQN8fiF_75gQ.

Mayne (2014). *Contribution Rubrics 1*.